

FINDING THE MISSING PIECE

* (Blue denotes power point)

* (Brown denotes instructions to technician)

TEXT: Ephesians 4:11-16 (NKJV) *“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, ¹²for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ, ¹³till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ; ¹⁴that we should no longer be children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the trickery of men, in the cunning craftiness of deceitful plotting, ¹⁵but, speaking the truth in love, may grow up in all things into Him who is the head—Christ— ¹⁶from whom the whole body, joined and knit together by what every joint supplies, according to the effective working by which every part does its share, causes growth of the body for the edifying of itself in love.”*

(Distribute a piece of a puzzle to everyone in the audience)

INTRO: Life is very much like a puzzle: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

A puzzle:

- Takes a while to come together.
- Has no hope of completion without all the pieces.

- Can never be complete until all the pieces are in the proper place.

Every human being was created for the purpose of worshipping and serving God. Anyone who is not fulfilling those aspects of his/her life will never know what real fulfillment is all about.

Our Scripture text provides the believer with all the pieces for a successful life. The real challenge is to determine how to place them in the proper order. The proper order varies from person to person. Just as each of us has a different fingerprint, each of us has a different purpose. I am not sure we realize how truly unique each of us is. DNA molecules can unite in a finite number of ways. The number is 10 to the two billion, four-hundred-millionth power. That number is the likelihood that you'd ever find somebody just like you. If you were to write out that number with each zero being one inch wide, you'd need a strip of paper 37,000 miles wide!

To put this in perspective, some scientists have guessed that all the particles in the universe are probably less than 10 with 76 zeros behind it, far less than the possibilities of your DNA. Our uniqueness is a scientific fact of life. When God made us, He broke the mold. There never has been, nor will there ever be, anybody exactly like us.

Several things go into arranging the pieces of our life so that we eventually become everything our creator intended us to be.

Over the next few weeks we will look at the pieces that if properly arranged will spell success both personally and spiritually. The pieces are: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Personality Discovery
- Learning to Utilize Spiritual Gifts
- Assessing our Abilities
- Connecting our Passions
- Employing Life Experience

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

God never wastes anything. He would not give us personality, gifts, abilities, passions and life experiences unless He intended to use them for His glory. By identifying and understanding these factors we can discover God's will for our life. The Bible says we have been created wonderfully complex. **Psalms 119:73 (AMP) “Thy hands have made me and fashioned (cunningly fashioned and established) me: give me understanding, that I may learn Thy commandments.”** **Psalms 119:73 (NLT) “You made me, You created me. Now give me the sense to follow Your commands.”** This Scripture lets us know that God hand crafted us for His purpose, the challenge each of us face is to determine what that purpose is and how to fit into His plan.

I. PERSONALITY DISCOVERY

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Whenever God gives us an assignment, He always equips us with what we need to accomplish it, He also grants an anointing for each task.

It is obvious that God loves variety. Just look around! He created each of us with a unique combination of personality traits; God made introverts and extroverts. He made people who love routine and those who love variety. He made some people thinkers and others feelers. He made some people to work best when given an individual assignment while others work better with a team. The Bible says in [1 Corinthians 12:6](#) (PHILLIPS) ***“God works through different people in different ways, but it is the same God who achieves His purpose through them all.”***

There is no right or wrong temperament for ministry. We need all kinds of personalities to balance the church and give it flavor. The world would be a very boring place if we were all plain vanilla. Fortunately, people come in more than thirty-one flavors.

Our personalities will affect how and where we use our spiritual gifts and abilities. [When we minister in a manner that is out of character with our temperament, it: \(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME\)](#)

- [Creates tension and discomfort](#)
- [Requires extra effort and energy](#)
- [Produces less than the best results](#)

God has uniquely wired each individual for a specific purpose. Even though we are wired for a purpose there are some [outside influences which tend to have](#)

an impact as well: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Environment
- Circumstances
- Expectations of others

The real tragedy is in not realizing who God created us to be and going through life wishing we could have a personality which is different from the one God has given us. There is no such thing as a bad personality. It is what you do with your personality that determines whether it is good or bad, a strength or weakness.

For instance, **the following things can be constructive or destructive: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Fire
- Water
- Guns

How we choose to direct our own spirit and deal with outside influences will determine: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Who we are
- How we act
- What we do

Merriam-Webster Dictionary defines **personality** as *“The dominant quality or qualities distinguishing a person or group.”* The American psychologist stresses the outward traits and dynamics when discussing personality. Europeans psychologists stress

inward traits and dynamics when discussing personality. At the end of the day, **personality is “*The inward and outward expression of emotional traits and characteristics that shape who we are, how we act, and what we do.*”** Jeremiah 1:5 (NLT) **“*Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, before you were born I set you apart; I appointed you as a prophet to the nations.*”** According to the Prophet Jeremiah, God gave us a personality before we were ever born and has used our environment, circumstances and expectations to shape our personality as it is today.

The Bible is full of people who God made different from one another, and then used these differences to accomplish His purpose: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Moses and Aaron** – Moses was a leader, Aaron was a follower.
- **Mary and Martha** – Mary was a worshipper, Martha was a doer.
- **Paul and Barnabas** – Paul was a disciplinarian, Barnabas was an encourager.
- **Jesus and Peter** – Jesus was the instructor, Peter was the student.

These men and women accomplished very different but equally important tasks for God because of their personality differences. I am convinced that much of the difference between success and failure within an organization has to do with understanding and appreciating the personality differences God has created us with. If we choose to understand the personalities of others we will reduce conflict.

Think of the personality ranges in this way. What will be needed for a church to present a drama and/or musical production? We will need:

- Director
- Script Writer
- Musical director
- Actors/Actresses
- Building Set/Props
- Technical Crew
- Promotional person or team

The church is much like a drama/musical. It takes all of God's people with different personalities to create a drama/musical called Church.

The discovery and acceptance of the personality God gifted us with is the first step to finding the missing piece of our lives.

II. LEARNING TO UTILIZE SPIRITUAL GIFTS

Studies have shown that Christians do not know what spiritual gifts are. Most Christians confuse natural talents with spiritual gifts. Natural talents are given to every human being at birth. Spiritual gifts are given by the Holy Spirit at the point of salvation. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** On the other hand, it is highly unlikely that God would not take a natural talent such as administration and make it a spiritual gift. In fact, God often seems to convert natural gifts into spiritual gifts.

God never asks a Christian to perform a role or use a spiritual gift without equipping them to perform it. In all cases, we are to be empowered by the Holy Spirit. [Philippians 4:13](#) (NKJV) ***"I Can do everything through him who gives me strength."***

I do not want to confuse the gifts of the Spirit in First Corinthians twelve with the discussion of spiritual gifts because they are two separate things. The gifts of the Spirit are primarily for the edification of the believer while spiritual gifts are to enhance the believers work for God.

Let us take a look at what the Bible has to say about spiritual gifts. [Romans 12:6](#) (NIV) ***"We have different gifts, according to the grace given us. If a man's gift is prophesying, let him use it in proportion to his faith."*** [James 1:17](#) (NIV) ***"Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, who does not change like shifting shadows."***

I would like us to look at a partial list of [spiritual gifts as they are revealed in the Word of God: \(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME\)](#)

- [The Gift of Administration](#) – This gift is a special trait given by God's Spirit to assist the body of Christ in the accomplishment of goals and plans. The gift of administration was one of the first gifts to be discovered in the first century church. (Appointment of Deacons Acts 6) Paul alludes to the fact that Titus had this gift. Titus 1:5 (NKJV) ***"For this reason I left you in***

Crete, that you should set in order the things that are lacking, and appoint elders in every city as I commanded you.”

- **The Gift of Apostleship** – This is a special feature given by the Spirit of God to gift certain individuals to mentor full-time vocational ministers to serve the church more effectively. Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, ¹²for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.”***
- **The Gift of Evangelism** – This gift is the special characteristic given by God’s Spirit to certain people within the body of Christ. Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, ¹²for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.”***
- **The Gift of Exhortation/Encouragement** – This is a special gift to encourage the body of Christ and to provide positive and practical steps for others to follow. Romans 12:6-8 (NKJV) ***“Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them: if prophecy, let us prophesy in proportion to our faith; ⁷or ministry, let us use it in our ministering; he who teaches, in teaching; ⁸he who exhorts, in exhortation; he who gives, with***

liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy with cheerfulness”

- **The Gift of Giving** – This is a special quality given by God’s Spirit to aid the believer in giving possessions and finances above a tithe to God’s work with a cheerful and willing spirit. Romans 12:6-8 (NKJV) *“Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them: if prophecy, let us prophesy in proportion to our faith; ⁷or ministry, let us use it in our ministering; he who teaches, in teaching; ⁸he who exhorts, in exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy with cheerfulness”* Someone said, “If God can get it through us, He will give it to us.”
- **The Gift of Helps** – This is the special attribute given by God’s Spirit to do just what it says – to help! 1 Corinthians 12:28 (NKJV) *“And God has appointed these in the church: first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, after that miracles, then gifts of healings, helps, administrations, varieties of tongues.”*
- **The Gift of Hospitality** – This is the special element given by God’s Spirit to allow certain people to cheerfully provide hospitality within the church. 1 Peter 4:9 (NKJV) *“Be hospitable to one another without grumbling.”* Acts 16:14-15 (NKJV) *“Now a certain woman named Lydia heard us. She was a seller of purple from the city of Thyatira, who worshiped God. The Lord opened her heart to heed the things spoken by Paul. ¹⁵And when*

she and her household were baptized, she begged us, saying, “If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord, come to my house and stay.” So she persuaded us. Martha of Bethany had this gift.

- **The Gift of Leadership** – This is a special feature given by God’s Spirit to provide direction and goals to a group and bring together resources and people that work together to accomplish the goals of the Kingdom of God. Romans 12:6-8 (NKJV) ***“Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them: if prophecy, let us prophesy in proportion to our faith; ⁷or ministry, let us use it in our ministering; he who teaches, in teaching; ⁸he who exhorts, in exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy with cheerfulness”***
- **The Gift of Mercy** – This gift is a special trait given by God’s Spirit to feel the hurt of others and genuinely express sympathy and provide comfort for those people. Romans 12:6-8 (NKJV) ***“Having then gifts differing according to the grace that is given to us, let us use them: if prophecy, let us prophesy in proportion to our faith; ⁷or ministry, let us use it in our ministering; he who teaches, in teaching; ⁸he who exhorts, in exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy with cheerfulness.”***
- **The Gift of Pastor/Shepherd** – This is a special characteristic given by God’s Spirit to guide,

protect, nurture, and feed a group of believers. This gift also carries with it the responsibility of growing the body of Christ into a group of mature believers. Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV)

“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,¹² for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.”

- **The Gift of Teaching** – This is a special quality given by God’s Spirit to communicate Biblical truths in a manner through which others can learn and understand these Biblical truths. Ephesians 4:11-12 (NKJV) ***“And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers,¹² for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.”***

Every believer should discover their gift and work to enhance that area of giftedness until they are able to function to the greatest level of effectiveness possible. Our gifts and abilities will be what we are judged by and they will have an eternal effect.

Discovering, utilizing, and developing the spiritual gifts in our lives is what is needed to find the missing piece.

III. ASSESSING OUR ABILITIES

When we mention abilities, we are speaking of an environment within which one feels most effective and

fulfilled. This environment can best be described as the atmosphere and circumstances in which one:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Most desires to work
- Feels the strengths of personality
- Is able to exercise God given gifts
- Is able to employ natural skills
- Is able to utilize training from the past

The definition of the word “*abilities*” is: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The quality or state of being able; competence in doing. The ability to use one's knowledge effectively and readily in execution or performance
- Dexterity or coordination especially in the execution of learned physical tasks
A learned power of doing something competently
- A developed aptitude or ability
- Natural aptitude or acquired proficiency

God always gives us gifts that have a connection to our abilities. In so doing He uses the two in tandem in addition to empowering us with the Holy Spirit and the three used together causes the believer to find the missing piece of their life and become effective for God as well as fulfilled in their pursuit of purpose.

[Zechariah 4:6](#) (KJV) “*Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the LORD of hosts.*”

What do our abilities consist of? The area we most naturally fit in to minister. What is our element? What do we have a knack for doing naturally?

ILLUSTRATION:

(Use a shovel, a hammer, and a large nail – Can you dig a hole with a hammer? Yes, but if given a choice one would choose the shovel. Can one drive a nail with a shovel? Possibly, but it is much easier to use a hammer)

I want us to look at **six types of abilities and their definitions: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Realistic** – A person with realistic abilities is practical and active and possesses good physical skills. They like to work outside and create things with their hands. They prefer to deal with things rather than ideas or people. Sometimes they have difficulty expressing their ideas and communicating their feelings to others. Their political and economic ideas are fairly conventional. They would describe themselves as rugged, robust, practical and physically strong.
- **Artistic** – A person with artistic abilities prefer unstructured situations where they can deal with problems through self-expression in an artistic medium. They usually prefer to work alone, or with just a few others. They have a great need for individualistic expression and are sensitive and emotional. They would describe themselves

as independent, original, unconventional and expressive.

- **Conventional** – A person with conventional abilities usually prefer highly ordered activities. They do not like to be the leader and usually like working in a well established chain of command. They like to know exactly what is expected of them and feel uncomfortable when they do not know the rules. They tend to see themselves as traditional, conventional, stable, well-controlled and dependable.
- **Enterprising** – People who possess enterprising abilities have great facility with words, which they can put to effective use in selling and leading. They enjoy persuading others to their viewpoints and become impatient with work involving precision or long periods of intellectual concentration. They see themselves as energetic, enthusiastic, adventurous, self-confident and dominant.
- **Social** – A person with social abilities are social, responsible and concerned with the welfare of others. They express themselves well and get along well with others. They like to be near the center of groups and prefer to solve problems by discussing them with others. They view themselves as cheerful, friendly, and popular. They tend to be high achievers and good leaders.
- **Investigative** – Those who possess investigative abilities prefer to solve abstract problems. They enjoy complicated problems and intellectual challenges. They do not like structured

situations with lots of rules or working around large groups of people.

According to [Albert Bandura](#) *“People’s beliefs about their abilities, have a profound effect on those abilities.”* For instance, Fred Floyd could give me a hundred lessons on how to rebuild an engine and you still would not want me to work on your car. On the other hand, If you give me the responsibility of selling an idea; leading a group of people; or solving a complex problem, I will excel in that environment. My abilities are enterprising and social.

We must all remember that God’s Word weighs in on this subject in [Philippians 4:13](#) (KJV) ***“I can do all things through Christ who strengtheneth me.”***

Philippians 4:13 (NLT) ***“For I can do everything with the help of Christ who gives me the strength I need.”***

Philippians 4:13 (AMP) ***“I have strength for all things in Christ Who empowers me [I am ready for anything and equal to anything through Him Who infuses inner strength into me; I am self-sufficient in Christ's sufficiency].”*** Philippians 4:13 (MSG) ***“Whatever I have, wherever I am, I can make it through anything in the One who makes me who I am.”***

Ability is not based solely on what you have, but WHO you have. We must also remember WHO made us who and how we are!

ILLUSTRATION

(The Little Engine that said; *“I think I can, I think I can . . .”*)

Success is not solely based on ability; many factors go into a successful life: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Gifts
- Abilities
- Reliance upon the Spirit
- A large dose of perseverance

Martin Seligman, Psychologist states *“It is the combination of reasonable talent and the ability to keep going in the face of defeat that leads to success.”*

Great achievements are never realized without some failures and defeats along the way! (Peter denied Christ and 50 day’s later preached one sermon and 3,000 people were converted) As believers, in the face of failure and defeat **we must keep four things in mind: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Our giftedness
- Our abilities
- The will of God
- The empowerment of the Holy Spirit

If we are to find the missing piece of our lives we must discover and assess our abilities, then utilize them to the greatest potential possible.

IV. CONNECTING OUR PASSIONS

Definitions for passion: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Passion is where we would give our time to serve people or tasks if money or the opinion of others were not a factor.
- Something that energizes one to the point that simply performing the task is the reward.

I love to see people who work in an area where they are passionate. Just as it thrills the heart of a parent to see their children grow up and work in a profession they love. By the same token, it must thrill the heart of God to see His children doing what they are passionate about. **Matthew 7:11 (NKJV) *“If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”***

Our staff is passionate about what they do. In fact each of them is so passionate about what they do, you do not need to talk to them very long until you discover that each of them believes their area of ministry should have priority because they see the ministry they serve as vital to the success of CT Church! If they were not passionate about their area of ministry they would not be on this staff.

Passion originates in the heart of an individual.

Proverbs 27:19 (KJV) *“As water reflects a face, so a man’s heart reflects a man.”* Proverbs 27:19 (NLT) ***“As a face is reflected in water, so the heart reflects the person.”***

Look at what the Bible has to say about the power of passion which originates in the heart. [Proverbs 4:23](#) (KJV) *“Keep thy heart with all diligence; for out of it are the issues of life.”* Notice three things in particular about this Scripture: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Keep](#) – Value or protect
- [Diligence](#) – As a watchman is charged with the responsibility of protecting against intruders, in the same way the individual is to protect his heart.
- [Issues](#) – Source of life. The issues of the heart are that which gets one going each morning.

We could paraphrase this Scripture to say; *“Protect your heart as a watchman guards against intruders; for out of the heart springs the things which get us going each morning.”*

The heart is the source of whatever affects life and character so it should be protected above everything else.

Passion comes from within; one person cannot give another person their passion. Passions are not transferable but experiences often produce our passions.

As you have time to go back and reflect on your personality, spiritual gifts, and abilities look and see if there is any correlation between these and the way you choose to demonstrate your passion.

Being in the wrong ministry can disconnect one's passion for ministry. When a person is involved in a ministry they are not passionate about they tend to:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Dread the next task
- Develop a bad attitude
- Become unfaithful to the ministry and church
- Fail to rise to the level of success that God intended for them

There are times when we will be required to do tasks within a ministry position that do not fit our unique design. However, there is a point when these tasks tip the scale in requiring someone to venture too far away, for too long a period of time, from their God-given design. When this happens, passion is lost and irreparable damage is done.

A rule of thumb should be that we should spend 80% of our time doing ministry tasks in line with our passions, while 20% of our time may have to be spent in tasks outside of our passions. It is unrealistic to expect we can spend 100% in activities that fit our passions. The 20% less desirable tasks usually are necessary to keep the opportunity of doing the 80% of more desirable tasks open to us. Keep in mind that this rule expresses what is optimal and we may not fully reach this optimal mix. While this may not always be possible this should be our goal.

With regard to our passions our acquaintances usually either contribute positively or negatively. Gordon MacDonald refers to five types of people that impact

our passion: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **VRP's** – Very resourceful people – These people ignite our passions. Whenever we are in their presence, we come away even more passionate about the passion that has already captured our hearts even though we may not share the same passions as our VRP's.
- **VIP's** – Very Important people – This person share our passions. When we are around them, they contribute positively to our passions.
- **VPP's** – Very passionate people - These people catch our passions. These are people who are able to see our passion and in turn create their own passion which is compatible with our passions. When this happens, it contributes to the re-energizing of our passion.
- **VNP's** – Very nice people – These people enjoy our passions. They neither contribute to nor take away from our passion they are encouragers who lend moral support to what we feel called to do.
- **VDP's** – Very drainable people - These people take our passions. If we spend too much time in the presence of VDP's (Very drainable people) without being re-energized by other people, our passion will begin to erode. Most people will need to spend more time in the presence of VRP's (Very resourceful people) than VDP's (Very drainable people) to stay passionate. For example, a person with the gift of mercy may spend huge amounts of time in the presence of VDP's (Very drainable people) and maintain

their passion but there will be times when they need to be in the presence of a VRP.

The amount of time we spend in the presence of each of these people will likely determine how passionate we become and how long we can remain passionate. Someone said, *"You can pick your friends, your family you are stuck with."* When it comes to our passions we must choose our cohorts wisely. The key is to realize when our passion is being disconnected by certain people and disconnect from them for a period of time and reconnect with someone who charges our batteries so to speak.

Some [deterrents to finding the missing piece in our lives](#): **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- [Over-commitment](#) – Reasons for this problem often include; poor time management; not being about to say no; and exhaustion. These things lead to over-commitment. When this happens what started as a passion can become sheer drudgery.
- [Boredom](#) - We were made to stretch ourselves. When we are not allowed to stretch and grow, we often become bored. When boredom sets in, areas we once had a passion for seem to lose their excitement. When this happens, boredom disconnects passion.
- [Incompetence](#) - Doing a task or job that we do not have the abilities and/or experience for will disconnect us from being passionate about that task. (I once had a book-keeper who was also a

very close and trusted friend. This person made a grave mistake and then asked, “*Are you going to fire me?*” My response was very simple; “*If you knew and did not perform your responsibility, you are negligent; if you did not know, you are incompetent. Either way you must go.*” Incompetence can never be tolerated at any level. Dr. Lawrence Peter who was a business guru in the 1960’s made famous what has become known as “The Peter Principle.” “The Peter Principle” states, “When people are promoted from their highest level of competence to one level above that, they hit their highest level of incompetence.” When this happens, workers lose passion for what they not only were passionate about at one time, but were also good at, and still are.

I think we should do church the Chick-Fil-A-Way! Chick-Fil-A does chicken and only chicken and they do it better than anyone else. We should all focus on doing one thing and doing it well! The one thing we commit to should be in the area which we are most passionate about. If anything [we should under commit and over deliver](#). When we do this we are within reach of the missing piece.

V. EMPLOYING LIFE EXPERIENCE

Romans 8:28 (KJV) “And we know that *all things work together for the good* of those who love God and are called according to His purposes.” Sometimes we have a tendency to complain about things that come into our lives which seem to be less than

desirable. We must never lose sight of the fact that if God is allowing it, there is a reason for it, and He will eventually use it for a ministry opportunity. (Job)

God does not say that all experiences are good. He says He causes all experiences to work for good. Certainly, someone losing a job is not a good experience, but for those who love God the experience will eventually work for good. Keep in mind that we cannot always see in the here and now how God works out every experience for good. We must learn to trust God that He is turning it for our good and for the good of the body of Christ.

Some of the experiences God uses for our good include: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Spiritual experiences** – God desires for every believer to become a mature Christian so that He can utilize that person to their highest level of effectiveness. When a person does not mature as God desires, they dumb down the destiny He has in mind for them.
- **Educational experiences** – If I know God wants me to be a college professor, I must pursue the education necessary to qualify myself for that role. (Britt and the Spanish church) Paul's experience in his religious upbringing was eventually used by God in many ways; it gave him credibility with Jewish converts to Christianity; allowed him to persuade Jews to convert to Christianity because he knew the Scriptures that spoke of the coming Messiah;

gave him the ability to dialog with people of other religions because he understood religious thinkers and how they reasoned.

- **Painful experiences** - Painful experiences that are common to us and can be used by God to accomplish a higher purpose would include; the loss of loved one; divorce; the loss of job; emotional abuse; physical abuse; sexual abuse; being falsely accused; addictions; persecution; and embarrassing situations.
- **Victorious experiences** – Jacob is a good example of how God took a failure (He deceived his brother and stole the birthright), and turn it into a victorious experience. Jacob means deceiver but God changed his name to Israel and as Paul Harvey would say, “*Now you know the rest of the story.*” Jacob’s struggle not only changed his life, but the course of history. An entire people and nation are named after him. Names in the OT had great significance and his name was given through an experience when he triumphed over adversity. **Genesis 32:24-28** (NKJV) ***“Then Jacob was left alone; and a Man wrestled with him until the breaking of day. ²⁵Now when He saw that He did not prevail against him, He touched the socket of his hip; and the socket of Jacob’s hip was out of joint as He wrestled with him. ²⁶And He said, “Let Me go, for the day breaks.” But he said, “I will not let You go unless You bless me!” ²⁷So He said to him, “What is your name?” He said, “Jacob.” ²⁸And He said, “Your name shall no longer be called Jacob,***

**but Israel; for you have struggled with God
and with men, and have prevailed.”**

The employment of life experience is easier to teach than to practice because we cannot see today what God is working toward tomorrow. The employment of life experience is a matter of trusting God. He can be trusted and we must trust Him with everything life throws in our pathway.

CONCLUSION:

Finding the missing piece of the puzzle called life is no easy task but there is no doubt it requires: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Personality Discovery
- Learning to Utilize Spiritual Gifts
- Assessing our Abilities
- Connecting our Passions
- Employing Life Experience

I challenge each of us to make a conscious decision that we will become all that God intended us to be and that we will not leave one stone unturned in our pursuit of finding the missing piece of our lives.